

Google steps in

Google plans to activate its remote kill switch to remotely uninstall apps from the over 2,60,000 handset affected by malware

Flash attack

According to Adobe's security advisory, there are reports of vulnerabilities in versions of Flash for Windows, Linux, Solaris and Android.

ANDROID

SECURE

SAFE

STABLE

REALLY?

In the midst of all the hype and hoopla surrounding Android, we take a closer look at the murky realities surrounding it...



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Android has very rapidly progressed with curiosity in 2007, fascination in 2009, and widespread adoption over the year gone by. It's good too, considering its openness, or rather "free and open source" ethos. On one side of it, there's praise being showered on Android: backed by Google! On the other, we find out...

It is estimated that a whopping 2,60,000 Android users are affected by malware and trojan attacks. Lately, there

was a similar case of 1,50,000 Gmail users having all their data wiped out from Google's servers. The reason was a backup software update going awry. The number of people affected was just 0.5 per cent of total Gmail users globally. Would you consider that to be serious? If you're not dependent on Google for email services you'd consider that to be a good record on Google's part. Unfortunately, chances are, you use Gmail, and you certainly

wouldn't want to be one of the affected. In a buzzing market of cellphones, spearheaded by smartphones, following precautionary measures would take you a long way in security. Altaf Halde, Country Director, Sophos shed some light on the security capabilities of Android. Describing the rapid growth of handheld devices, he said, "In the last few years, we've witnessed a radical change in the way we access and use the internet. The rapid upswing in sophistication of mobile technology resulted in a swift change in the way we provide mobile content and interact with it. However, this change brings with it a wealth of new problems for security."

It isn't surprising then, that mobile attacks have grown and now resemble the space in web security five years ago.

In platforms such as Android, some components are built into parts of the operating system, and therefore require full OS upgrades to patch vulnerabilities. This causes issues for some older devices that can't run newer editions of the platform. The openness of the Linux-based platform makes it possible to access and tinker with low-level components, but also attracts more research into possible flaws and how they might be exploited for profit. He adds, "all in all, Android phones represent a considerable exposure point, but again one that relies heavily on social engineering to lure users into installing rogue or malicious applications that give the bad guys access to their phones."

Attacks in the past...

Venkatasubrahmanyam Krishnapur, Senior Director of Engineering, CMSB, McAfee India shared some insight specific to Android with us. According to him, "As Android gains in market share, the threats to this platform are rapidly increasing as well." Some of the Android specific malwares that McAfee has discovered in recent times are:

"No vendor or mobile OS is immune"

Venkatasubrahmanyam Krishnapur,
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